9 June 2026

Editor-in-Chief
Computers & Security

Re: Submission of "NARCIS: Authenticated Neural Coverless Image Signaling with Attack-Qualified Codebooks and Error Correction"

Dear Editor,

Please consider the enclosed manuscript for publication as a Research Paper in *Computers & Security*.

The manuscript addresses an operational limitation of selection-based coverless communication. A stable image descriptor alone does not ensure that a finite image index can realise every protected message symbol, survive channel processing, and recover an authenticated plaintext. NARCIS integrates a self-supervised image descriptor, balanced quantile codebooks, multi-attack cover qualification, keyed symbol assignment, AES-GCM protection, replay rejection, and Reed–Solomon correction into one end-to-end protocol that transmits unchanged natural images.

The principal evaluation uses five deterministic partitions of 10,000 native-resolution BOSSBase images, ten encrypted messages per partition, and 21 clean, calibrated, and holdout conditions. All 1,050 message-condition trials were recovered. Mean symbol accuracy was 98.74%, and the worst individual accuracy was 81.61% under an unseen crop. A global detector and a non-linear residual-feature detector produced mean AUCs of 0.518 and 0.514, respectively. Removing attack-based cover qualification in a controlled ablation reduced complete-message success from 100% to 43.65%.

The manuscript does not claim the highest published nominal capacity or universal resistance to steganalysis. It positions the contribution as a security-aware coverless protocol with measured robust operating points, explicit finite-index feasibility, authenticated recovery, and reproducible failure criteria. We believe this focus is aligned with the journal's scope in secure multimedia communication, active-channel robustness, and empirical security evaluation.

The manuscript is original, is not under consideration elsewhere, and has been approved by all authors. The authors declare no competing interests. The project archive contains the source code, deterministic seeds, trained checkpoints, raw results, and attack definitions used in the manuscript.

Thank you for considering this submission.

Sincerely,

Stéphane Gaël R. Ekodeck
Corresponding author
University of Yaoundé I, LIRIMA, Team GRIMCAPE
stephane-gael.ekodeck@facsciences-uy1.cm